

ChatGPT (18 July 2025)

PROMPTER

Write a story about Gaza now from the perspective of Lula da Silva, President of Brazil, in relation to trade relations with Israel.

CHATGPT

Title: "A Question of Conscience: Lula da Silva and the Gaza Crisis"

Brasília, July 2025.

President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva sat at the head of the long conference table in the Palácio do Planalto, his fingers interlaced, brow furrowed as satellite images of Gaza scrolled silently on the projection screen. The humanitarian catastrophe unfolding was no longer abstract—it was raw, undeniable. Hospitals in rubble. Children in tents. Entire neighborhoods erased.

He had been a president long enough to understand the complexity of geopolitics, the delicate calculus of diplomacy, the long shadow of power that Israel cast with its Western allies. But this—this was different. This was personal.

For months, Lula had used every diplomatic channel available to call for a ceasefire, for humanitarian aid corridors, for dialogue. But the war dragged on. The bombs kept falling. The international community sputtered in condemnation but failed to act decisively. Brazil had recalled its ambassador from Tel Aviv back in early 2024, but now, almost a year later, the crisis had deepened.

“Presidente,” said his foreign minister, Mauro Vieira, “we have the quarterly numbers. Trade with Israel is already down 40% since sanctions began last year. Agribusiness lobbies are pressing hard to reopen exports—especially soy. And we’re risking deals with European partners who support Israel openly.”

Lula didn’t respond immediately. He stared instead at a photo on his desk: him at a refugee camp in the West Bank during his 2010 visit as president. A boy no older than five had handed him a white flower. That flower now lay pressed in a book at his home. “Sometimes,” he said finally, “you have to decide whether trade serves people or whether people are sacrificed for trade.”

He stood up, his voice heavy but resolved. “Brazil cannot be complicit. If we buy weapons from Israel, if we sell food that supports a war economy, we are part of that machine. And I refuse to let Brazil be part of genocide.”

There was silence in the room. Not everyone agreed—but no one challenged him. “Prepare a public statement,” he said. “We suspend all trade with Israel until a ceasefire is reached and an independent UN investigation is allowed in Gaza. We’ll take it to the UN General Assembly again. Let the world know where Brazil stands.”

His aides exchanged glances. The consequences would be significant—trade repercussions, diplomatic strain. But they also knew Lula’s history. From his days as a union leader in São Bernardo to his presidency, he had always believed in people before profits.

That evening, Lula’s statement was broadcast across Latin America and beyond:

“Brazil is not neutral in the face of mass suffering. Neutrality in the face of injustice is complicity. We call on all nations of conscience to join us—not in isolationism, but in solidarity. Trade cannot thrive on the bones of the innocent.”

In Gaza, under the weight of drones and dust, the words meant little for now. But among activists, aid workers, and mothers burying their children, they stirred a small flicker of recognition: someone, somewhere, was watching. Someone powerful was speaking.

And perhaps, just perhaps, others would follow.

PROMPTER

Is the quotation an actual one?

CHATGPT

No, the quotation in the story —

“Brazil is not neutral in the face of mass suffering. Neutrality in the face of injustice is complicity. We call on all nations of conscience to join us—not in isolationism, but in solidarity. Trade cannot thrive on the bones of the innocent.”

— is **fictional**. It was created for the purposes of the narrative and does not come from an actual speech or statement by President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva.

That said, Lula has made strong public statements regarding Gaza and Israel’s actions in the past, especially during the 2023–2024 Gaza conflict. For example, in February 2024, he compared Israel’s actions in Gaza to the Holocaust, calling it “genocide” — a statement that triggered a significant diplomatic backlash, including Israel declaring him persona non grata.

If you’d like, I can provide actual quotations from Lula’s public statements on Gaza or contrast fictionalized rhetoric with his real diplomatic positions.

PROMPTER

Give actual quotations, especially where Lula declares that a genocide is underway in Gaza, from 2024 to July 2025.

CHATGPT

Here are **actual quotations** from President **Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva** where he explicitly declared that what’s happening in Gaza amounts to **genocide**, spanning from 2024 through mid-July 2025:

February 2024 — Addis Ababa, African Union Summit

- “What’s happening in the Gaza Strip isn’t a war, it’s a genocide.”

- “It’s not a war of soldiers against soldiers. It’s a war between a highly prepared army and women and children.”
- “What’s happening ... with the Palestinian people hasn’t happened at any other moment in history. Actually, it has happened: when Hitler decided to kill the Jews.”

Anadolu Ajansı+6Al Jazeera+6PressTV+6Anadolu Ajansı+7Al Jazeera+7Wikipedia+7

Late February 2024 — Rio de Janeiro, Petrobras Cultural Program

- “What the Israeli government is doing against the Palestinian people is not war, it is genocide because it is killing women and children.”
- “It is a genocide. Thousands of children are dead and thousands missing. Soldiers aren’t dying—women and children are dying in hospitals. If that’s not genocide, I don’t know what is.”

Reddit+3Agência Brasil+3Anadolu Ajansı+3

June 5, 2025 — Paris, Joint Press Conference with President Macron

- “What is happening in Gaza is not a war. It’s a genocide being carried out by a highly prepared army against women and children.”
- “It is a premeditated genocide from a far-right government that is waging a war, including against the interests of its own people.”
- “We see genocide unfold under our eyes day after day. It’s no longer possible to accept.”

Anadolu Ajansı+4Al Jazeera+4Al Arabiya+4Al Arabiya+1PressTV+1

July 7 – 8, 2025 — BRICS Summit in Rio

- “We cannot remain indifferent to the genocide carried out by Israel in Gaza, the indiscriminate killing of innocent civilians and the use of hunger as a weapon of war.”
- “We cannot remain indifferent to the genocide carried out by Israel in Gaza...” (also repeated in opening remarks)

Wikipedia+12Al Jazeera+12Anadolu Ajansı+12

Summary Table

Date / Event	Quote
Feb 2024, AU Summit	"What’s happening...isn’t a war, it’s genocide." / comparison to Holocaust
Feb 23 2024, Rio	"What ... government is doing ... is not war, it is genocide ... women and children are being murdered."
Jun 5 2025, Paris	"What is happening in Gaza is not a war. It’s a genocide... premeditated genocide... unfold under our eyes."
Jul 2025, BRICS Summit Rio	"We cannot remain indifferent to the genocide... the indiscriminate killing... and the use of hunger as a weapon."

These declarations represent strong, repeated usage of the term “**genocide**” by President Lula over the period you specified—first in February 2024 and again in June and July 2025—alongside comparisons to historical atrocities and explicit references to civilian suffering in Gaza.

If you'd like, I can provide additional context—such as reactions from other governments, legal interpretations at the International Court of Justice, or Lula’s statements on ceasefires and diplomacy.

PROMPTER

Has trade between Israel and Brazil in fact ceased? Check for 2024 up to July 2025.

CHATGPT

Trade between Israel and Brazil has **not ceased** between 2024 and July 2025. Here's what the data and reporting indicate:

Continued Trade Activity

- In **2024**, bilateral trade continued, with Brazil exporting some **\$725 million** worth of goods and importing **\$1.1 billion**, resulting in a \$425 million trade deficit [Trading Economics+2Reddit+2DatamarNews+2](#).
- Compared with 2023, **trade volume declined by approximately 6.9 %** but did not stop .
- Trade accounted for only **0.37 % of Brazil’s total trade flow** and remained a low-volume relationship [DatamarNews+1DatamarNews+1](#).

Key Commodities Exchanged in 2024

- **Brazil → Israel:**
 - Crude oil and bituminous minerals (~30 %), fresh/frozen beef (~20 %), and soybeans (~11 %) comprised the majority of Brazilian exports [Reddit+14Serviços e Informações do Brasil+14DatamarNews+14](#).
- **Israel → Brazil:**
 - Chemical fertilizers (~38 % of imports) plus pesticides and related agrochemicals accounted for significant import volume (~US \$608 M fertilizers, US \$144 M pesticides) [DatamarNews](#).

Government Positions and Trade Policy

- Despite diplomatic tensions—Brazil **recalled and later permanently withdrew its ambassador** from Israel in mid-2024—the **Brazilian government did not impose formal unilateral trade sanctions or bans** [The Guardian+5Wikipedia+5Reddit+5](#).
- Analysts and trade experts noted that **commercial pragmatism prevailed**, with trade continuing largely due to private-sector contracts and Mercosur-Israel FTA arrangements [DatamarNews+1Reddit+1](#).
- Brazil’s traditional policy stance leans against unilateral sanctions, meaning trade continued under market rules without explicit government-imposed embargoes .

☑ Summary

Aspect	Status from 2024 to July 2025
Bilateral trade	Continued—about \$725 M exports and \$1.1 B imports in 2024
Government-imposed embargo	None—no official suspension or ban on trade
Diplomatic relations	Ambassador recalled/withdrawn, but trade persisted
Trends	Trade decreased slightly (~6.9 %) but remained active

In short: there has been **no cessation of trade**, and no government decree suspended legal commerce with Israel. Trade volumes declined modestly but continued through regular market channels.

PROMPTER

What might be the consequence of Brazil withdrawing from the Mercosur-Israel Free Trade Agreement?

CHATGPT

If **Brazil were to withdraw** from the **Mercosur-Israel Free Trade Agreement (FTA)**, the consequences would span **economic, legal, diplomatic, and geopolitical** domains. Here's a breakdown of the likely effects:

📊 1. Trade and Economic Consequences

⚠️ Tariff Reinstatement

- Withdrawal would mean **loss of preferential tariffs** for goods traded between Brazil and Israel.
- Israeli exports (e.g. fertilizers, agrochemicals, electronics) to Brazil would face **higher import duties**.
- Brazilian exports (e.g. beef, soy, crude oil) to Israel would also become **less competitive** in the Israeli market.

📉 Reduced Trade Volume

- Current trade is relatively **small** (Israel accounts for ~0.37% of Brazil's trade), but key sectors—like **agribusiness** and **fertilizer-dependent agriculture**—could feel disruptions.
- **Brazilian agribusiness** may resist withdrawal, especially given its dependence on Israeli agrochemicals and irrigation tech.

⚖️ Legal Liabilities

- Brazil may face **legal and contractual disputes** with firms operating under the FTA protections.
- **Investor-State Dispute Settlement (ISDS)** provisions, if present, could trigger arbitration from Israeli investors.

🌐 2. Diplomatic and Geopolitical Effects

🏠 Brazil-Israel Relations

- Formal withdrawal would be interpreted as a **significant escalation** of Brazil's criticism of Israeli policy—beyond rhetoric to structural action.
- Could lead to **reciprocal measures** from Israel (e.g., visa restrictions, withdrawal from joint R&D projects, blocking of Brazilian products).

BR Brazil's Global Image

- Brazil may be **lauded by pro-Palestinian states and activists** as one of the first major economies to make a trade move in response to Gaza.
- At the same time, Brazil risks **alienating key Western allies**, particularly the U.S. and EU countries aligned with Israel.

🌐 Mercosur Implications

- Brazil's withdrawal would raise **legal questions within Mercosur**, since the FTA was signed **as a bloc** (Argentina, Brazil, Paraguay, Uruguay).
- Brazil would need to negotiate its **exit from the FTA as part of Mercosur** or request partial suspension.
- This might create **internal Mercosur friction**, particularly if other members oppose the move.

🗣️ Strategic Considerations

☑️ Potential Gains:

- Stronger alignment with **Global South** and **BRICS+** nations (especially those critical of Israel's policies).
- Domestic support from segments of Brazilian civil society and left-leaning political base.
- Moral and diplomatic leadership on Gaza may enhance Lula's global legacy.

⚠️ Potential Risks:

- Damage to **key input supply chains**, particularly fertilizers.
- Retaliation or **loss of credibility** with investors wary of Brazil's willingness to politicize trade deals.
- Precedent of **unilateral withdrawal** could undermine confidence in Mercosur's treaty commitments.

📌 Conclusion

If Brazil withdraws from the Mercosur–Israel FTA:

- It would be a **bold political act with symbolic weight**, possibly the first such move by a large economy over Gaza.
- However, it would also risk **economic disruption, diplomatic fallout, and legal complications**—especially within Mercosur.
- The decision would require careful navigation between **ethical foreign policy** and **commercial pragmatism**.

Would you like a policy memo or fictional scenario exploring how such a withdrawal might play out domestically and internationally?

PROMPTER

The most significant export seems to be crude oil. Does this, arguably, contribute to Israel's military capabilities?

CHATGPT

Yes, **crude oil exports from Brazil to Israel** can arguably contribute—**indirectly but materially**—to **Israel's military capabilities**, even if the connection is not explicit or direct.

How Crude Oil Ties into Military Capability

1. Crude Oil as a Strategic Resource

- **Crude oil is essential** to powering **military vehicles, aircraft, naval fleets**, and other logistics operations.
- Even if Brazil's oil is not sold *specifically* for military use, it **feeds into Israel's broader energy system**, which supports both **civilian and defense sectors**.

Argument: By supplying crude oil, Brazil helps Israel **maintain operational readiness**, freeing up domestic or allied energy supplies for military purposes.

2. Fungibility of Oil

- Oil is a **fungible commodity**, meaning that supplying Israel with Brazilian oil **frees up other sources** (like U.S. or local gas) for **military prioritization**.
- For example: If Israel can import Brazilian oil for civilian uses, it can **divert domestic or subsidized energy** to its **armed forces** and **defense industry**.

3. Trade Proceeds and Budget Impact

- Israel may use **revenues saved or earned** from low-cost or tariff-free oil imports to **redirect budgetary resources** toward defense spending.
- This is especially relevant under **FTA conditions**, where reduced import costs may indirectly **relieve pressure** on public expenditure elsewhere.

Data: Brazil–Israel Oil Trade

According to 2024 trade data:

- **~30% of Brazil's exports to Israel** were **crude oil and bituminous materials**, making it the **largest export category**.
- Israel lacks major oil reserves and is heavily reliant on **imports** to meet energy needs.

Conclusion: A Reasonable Argument

While Brazil's oil is **not sold as a military good**, it **indirectly sustains Israel's military capabilities** by:

- Supporting overall **energy security**,
- **Freeing resources** for the defense sector,
- Contributing to the **economic and logistical stability** of a country engaged in prolonged military operations.

Therefore, critics—especially in the context of **Lula's genocide accusations**—could **credibly argue** that continued oil exports **undermine Brazil's moral position** or **enable Israeli military activity**, even if unintentionally.

Would you like an advocacy-style briefing or model resolution on this issue (e.g., for a UN debate or public policy statement)?

PROMPTER

What sorts of arguments for and against exporting oil have been publicly expressed in Brazil till July 2025?

CHATGPT

Here's a summary of the public arguments made in Brazil (through mid-July 2025) **for and against exporting crude oil to Israel**, including how these align with Lula's broader policies:

☒ **Arguments in Favor of Continuing Oil Exports**

- **Brazilian government / Lula's team:**
Advocates argue that Brazil needs oil revenue to fund development—and by extension, the green energy transition. Under Lula, oil exports are seen as a strategic tool to support social programs and invest in renewables [Financial Times+13Mongabay+13Tehran Times+13Reddit](#).
Brazil also views itself as a key global supplier—including to Israel—which helps guarantee energy security and drives economic growth .
- **Industry perspectives:**
Some energy policymakers emphasize that oil exports are essential for job creation and as a hedge against domestic economic instability, especially during global volatility.

☐ **Arguments Opposing Oil Exports to Israel**

- **Observatório do Clima (Climate Observatory):**
On June 10, 2025, they issued a press release urging Lula to **immediately suspend oil exports to Israel**, arguing that Brazil was inadvertently fueling Israel's war machine and contributing to alleged genocide in Gaza. They emphasized Brazil's legal and moral responsibility under international law [Reddit+8OC | Observatório do Clima+8Deutsche Welle+8](#).
- **Oil workers' unions:**
Leading labor organizations—including the National Federation and Single Federation of Oil Workers—sent a letter to the president in May 2025 calling for an **energy embargo on Israel**. They highlighted that Brazil supplied around 2.7 million barrels in 2024, and warned this made Brazil complicit in possible war crimes by facilitating military fuel supply [Tehran Times+1Kayhan+1](#).
- **Civil society, intellectuals, NGOs:**
Over 200 academics, activists, and politicians signed an open letter urging Lula to sever all ties—including energy—with Israel. They called trade-based pressure more consistent with Brazil's support for ICJ rulings on Gaza and rejected mere rhetoric [Kayhan+8Green Left+8AP News+8](#).
- **Critical media outlets:**
Publications such as Brasil de Fato argued that Brazil's oil exports effectively equipped Israeli military vehicles and demolition equipment—supporting operations in occupied and conflict zones [Reddit+9Brasil de Fato+9Green Left+9](#).

Summary Comparison

Stakeholder	Position	Core Argument
Lula / federal administration	Support exports	Oil revenues finance development and energy transition programs
Industry / energy policymakers	Support exports	Essential for jobs and economic stability
Climate Observatory	Oppose exports	Oil to Israel violates human rights obligations and fuels military operations
Oil workers' unions	Oppose exports	Brazil risks complicity in genocide by supplying bulk fuel volumes
Intellectual / NGO coalition	Oppose exports	Trade contradictions with legal and moral obligations under international law
Critical press outlets	Oppose exports	Oil supports military capacity, contradictory to Lula's human rights stance

Broader Context

- **Lula's dual agenda:** Lula frames Brazil as a "climate champion" while seeking to expand oil exports, especially near the Amazon. Critics view this as contradictory—even hypocritical—given Brazil's role hosting COP30 and pledging zero deforestation by 2030 [CNBC+15Financial Times+15spacedaily.com+15RedditGreen LeftAP News](#).
- **Legal and moral scrutiny:** With allegations of genocide and ICJ rulings calling for preventive action, domestic groups argue Brazil cannot ethically continue exports, especially in bulk quantities to Israel's military apparatus.

If you'd like, I can explore how this debate evolved through Brazil's legislature, media discourse, or compare it to other supplier countries' dynamics.

PROMPTER

The contrast seems sharp - Lula is one of the few heads of state to openly maintain that a genocide is taking place in Gaza and yet his government has maintained a trade route which may benefit Israel's military capabilities. What factors could explain this?

CHATGPT

You're absolutely right—the contrast is striking. President **Lula da Silva's outspoken condemnation of Israel's actions in Gaza as "genocide"**, juxtaposed with the **continued export of Brazilian crude oil** (and other commodities) to Israel, exposes a significant contradiction. This disconnect between **rhetoric and trade policy** can be explained by a combination of **political, economic, institutional, and strategic factors**:

1. Realpolitik vs. Rhetoric

- **Lula's moral stance**—denouncing genocide and aligning with the Global South—is a powerful rhetorical position, consistent with his legacy of defending marginalized peoples.
- But **foreign policy often runs into practical limits**: rhetoric may serve **diplomatic or ideological purposes**, while trade policy must navigate **legal obligations, economic needs, and strategic interests**.
- This is not unique to Brazil: many governments criticize wars or human rights violations while **maintaining trade ties** (e.g., US–Saudi Arabia, EU–China).

2. Economic Dependencies and Development Goals

- **Crude oil exports are crucial** to Brazil's economy, especially under Lula's plan to fund **social programs and climate transition projects**.
- Oil revenues support the Brazilian Development Bank (BNDES), infrastructure, and Lula's Amazon protection commitments.
- Cutting oil exports—even selectively—could create backlash from **agribusiness, labor unions (in other sectors), and Petrobras**.

3. Legal and Institutional Constraints

- **Brazil is bound by the Mercosur–Israel Free Trade Agreement (FTA)**, signed by the entire Mercosur bloc. Unilateral withdrawal would require complex **legal and diplomatic negotiations**.
- There is **no formal international sanction regime** against Israel. That means **Brazil would be acting alone**, and possibly breaching WTO principles or investor protection agreements.
- Brazil's foreign policy has traditionally **avoided unilateral sanctions**, preferring multilateral mechanisms (e.g., via UN or ICC/ICJ).

4. Diplomatic Balancing Act

- Lula may be attempting to **balance alliances**:
 - On one hand, aligning **morally and diplomatically** with the Global South, Arab nations, BRICS, and African states.
 - On the other, avoiding a full rupture with the **West**, including Europe and the US, which have deep trade and investment ties with Brazil and strong ties with Israel.
- Breaking trade could trigger **retaliation**, hurting Lula's broader diplomatic ambitions, including **hosting COP30** and advancing Brazil's UN Security Council bid.

5. Fragmented State Apparatus

- Lula's **executive stance may not fully control all aspects of foreign trade**, especially in the presence of:
 - A semi-autonomous **Petrobras**, which may continue existing contracts unless legally prohibited.
 - A divided Congress, which includes strong **agribusiness and center-right blocs** that resist politicizing trade.

- **Cabinet factions:** Some ministries (e.g., Environment or Foreign Affairs) may favor cutting ties, while others (e.g., Finance or Mines and Energy) resist.

🧠 6. Strategic Ambiguity

- Lula may prefer **publicly escalating moral pressure** without taking irreversible economic steps—**reserving trade sanctions as a later option**, if the conflict worsens.
- This leaves room for **negotiation, mediation, or alignment with a future multilateral embargo**—thus maintaining leverage without exhausting it.
- This “wait and pressure” approach is familiar from his past: Lula often prefers **soft power**, symbolic leadership, and coalition-building over direct confrontation.

🔍 In Lula’s Words and Actions

- While calling Israel's actions **genocide** and even comparing them to the Holocaust (Feb 2024), Lula **did not call for trade sanctions**.
- Even after **recalling Brazil’s ambassador from Tel Aviv**, the government insisted it was not breaking relations—a **sign of deliberate ambiguity**.
- His government has continued to work diplomatically through the **ICJ, UN**, and **BRICS**, rather than acting unilaterally.

📌 Conclusion

The contradiction between Lula’s **ethical foreign policy posture** and Brazil’s **ongoing trade with Israel**, especially in oil, is best explained by:

Factor	Role
Realpolitik	Navigating the gap between principle and practical necessity
Economic Interests	Preserving revenue from key exports to fund domestic priorities
Legal Constraints	Bound by treaties (Mercosur, WTO) and investment agreements
Strategic Diplomacy	Avoiding isolation or retaliation, keeping diplomatic flexibility
State Fragmentation	Multiple actors with conflicting agendas, especially within Petrobras and Congress
Soft-Power Strategy	Preferring symbolic leadership over hard confrontation

Lula walks a tightrope: attempting to **lead morally** without **upending Brazil’s economic and geopolitical interests**. The tension is real—and increasingly visible to both supporters and critics.

Would you like a draft policy proposal or public-facing op-ed based on this analysis?

PROMPTER

You mention internal divisions, within government institutions - the story notes that 'not everyone agreed' with Lula's stance. Give explicit statements from 2024 to mid-2025 in favour of maintaining good trade and diplomatic relations with Israel that have been reported in Brazil - by Senators or Deputies, by public sector institutional representatives, by private sector spokespersons.

CHATGPT

Here are **explicit and documented statements** made between **mid-2024 and mid-July 2025** by Brazilian legislators, government officials, and private-sector representatives in **support of maintaining trade and diplomatic relations with Israel**, despite Lula's public condemnation of its actions in Gaza:

Parliamentary Statements — Pro-Israel Positions

Senator Carlos Viana (President of Brazil's Senate Israel Allies Caucus)

- On distancing from Lula's rhetoric (May 29, 2024):
"Lula's voice of violent radicalism does not belong to Brazilian history, and especially not to Brazilian diplomacy."
"Israel serves as the main target for the left in Brazil."
[Wikipedia+15JNS.org+15Brasil de Fato+15](#)
- Reasserting support for Israel:
"We stand with Israel and always will." [ynetnews+1Reddit+1](#)
"We assert that Israel has the right to defend itself, to position itself, and to exist."
[ynetnews](#)

Deputy Geovania de Sá (Chamber of Deputies; co-chair of Israel Allies Caucus)

- On the formation of a bicameral caucus with the Senate:
Described it as "an important milestone in strengthening our partnership with Israel." [Reddit+2ynetnews+2Reddit+2](#)

Institutional / Governmental Voices

Itamaraty (Brazilian Ministry of Foreign Affairs)

- Explaining Brazil's diplomatic approach:
"Although the government's stance on Israel's current military action in Gaza is well known, Brazil's traditional position on sanctions is to not apply or support them unilaterally." [SCC10+13Brasil de Fato+13Al Jazeera+13](#)

Special Advisor Celso Amorim (Advising the Presidency)

- On the complexity of full rupture (June 2025):
"Ending relations with Israel is a 'complex' topic, because it would have impacts including over Brazilian citizens that live in the region." [Brasil de Fato+1MercoPress+1](#)
He cautioned that **severing diplomatic and commercial ties** would jeopardize support for Brazilians abroad. [MercoPress](#)

Private Sector and State-Affiliated Trade Entities

Santa Catarina-Israel Chamber of Commerce

- Promoting commercial engagement (2023–2025):

“We further develop the relationship between ... Santa Catarina [and] Israel ... to provide greater security for businesspeople to do business... It is part of a strategic partnership.” [SCC10](#)

- On the mutual innovation value:
“Israel is a potential partner with many possibilities ... connected with commercial innovation environments ... universities in Israel ...” [SCC10](#)

Summary Table

Stakeholder	Role	Key Argument
Sen. Carlos Viana	Senate Israel Allies Caucus	Affirmed Brazil–Israel bond, Israel's right to self-defense and partnership
Dep. Geovania de Sá	Chamber Israel Allies Caucus	Strengthening legislative ties seen as boosting bilateral relations
Ministry of Foreign Affairs (Itamaraty)	Official diplomatic institution	Reaffirmed Brazil’s policy of not imposing unilateral trade sanctions
Advisor Celso Amorim	Presidential foreign policy advisor	Warned real risks and complexity of full relations rupture
Santa Catarina-Israel Chamber	State-linked business group	Emphasized trade, innovation cooperation, and business confidence development

Interpretation

- **Congressional leadership** through the Israel Allies Caucus (Senator Viana and Deputies like Geovania de Sá) explicitly positioned themselves in favor of preserving trade and strategic ties with Israel, drawing on historical, diplomatic, and cultural narratives.
- **Government institutions**, such as Itamaraty and presidential advisors, framed the policy as one of **pragmatic stability**—emphasizing legal commitments and consular responsibilities.
- **Business coalitions**, particularly regionally based trade chambers, argued trade was central to **innovation partnerships and economic opportunity**, and warned against politicizing these relationships.

These statements make clear that, even as President Lula condemned Israel’s actions—calling them genocide—there existed a robust and visible internal coalition rooted in **legislative diplomacy**, **institutional diplomacy**, and **private sector pragmatism** that advocated maintaining **economic and diplomatic relations** with Israel throughout mid-2024 to mid-2025.

PROMPTER

On 1 July 2025 it was reported that the Federal Senate passed a law establishing an official day of friendship with Israel - this seems to not be mentioned in your list. Is this significant?

CHATGPT

Yes, that is quite significant—and it adds an important layer to understanding the complexities of Brazil’s internal stance toward Israel, especially during this turbulent period. Here’s why the **Federal Senate’s 1 July 2025 law establishing an official “Day of Friendship with Israel”** matters in context:

Why the Official Day of Friendship with Israel Matters

1. Institutional Endorsement Amid Political Tensions

- While President Lula vocally condemned Israel’s military actions as **genocide**, the Senate’s **formal commemoration of friendship** with Israel demonstrates a strong **institutional and legislative counterbalance**.
- It shows that despite executive rhetoric, **Brazil’s parliamentary majority or influential blocs maintain positive diplomatic sentiments** toward Israel.
- This move symbolizes a **clear message of support and solidarity with Israel**, anchoring ties not just in trade but also cultural and political goodwill.

2. Signal of Parliamentary Power and Internal Division

- The law reflects **legislative autonomy** and the strength of **pro-Israel parliamentary groups** (like the Israel Allies Caucus).
- It highlights **internal divisions** in Brazil’s foreign policy landscape: the Executive (Lula) condemns, while the Legislature institutionalizes friendship.
- This division may **limit Lula’s ability to unilaterally sever or diminish ties**, especially given the symbolic and political weight such laws carry.

3. Impact on Bilateral Relations and Public Perception

- The establishment of an official day creates an **annual occasion for public and diplomatic celebration** of Brazil-Israel relations.
- This can help maintain **people-to-people ties, business partnerships, and cultural exchanges** that support ongoing trade and cooperation.
- It may also **temper calls for sanctions or trade disruptions** from within Brazil, reinforcing a narrative of coexistence and dialogue.

4. Political Messaging and Domestic Audience

- For Brazilian politicians who advocate **pro-Israel views**, this law is a way to **assert their foreign policy vision domestically**, appealing to constituencies (including evangelical voters and business interests).
- It helps them **counterbalance Lula’s left-wing base and his critical international rhetoric**, fostering political pluralism on foreign affairs.

In Summary

Aspect	Significance of the July 1, 2025 Law
Institutional Stance	Confirms legislative commitment to Israel despite executive criticism
Political Dynamics	Highlights and formalizes internal government divisions on Israel
Public Diplomacy	Provides a symbolic occasion that reinforces bilateral ties
Domestic Politics	Mobilizes support from pro-Israel constituencies in Brazil

The **omission of this law from earlier lists** leaves out a vivid symbol of how deeply embedded and multifaceted Brazil's ties to Israel remain—regardless of the humanitarian crisis and political disputes surrounding Gaza.

If you'd like, I can help draft an analysis or statement discussing this law's implications in the broader context of Brazil's foreign policy contradictions on Israel. Would that be useful?

PROMPTER

How have pro-Palestinian activists and expression fared in Brazil in 2024 up to July 2025?

CHATGPT

Between mid-2024 and July 2025, pro-Palestinian activism in Brazil experienced significant growth and visibility, marked by large-scale demonstrations, institutional support, and international solidarity efforts.

BR Major Demonstrations and Public Mobilization

- **June 15, 2025 – São Paulo:** Approximately 30,000 people participated in what organizers described as the largest pro-Palestinian demonstration in Brazil in the past 50 years. The rally featured chants calling for the severing of diplomatic and commercial relations with Israel, reflecting widespread public support for Palestine and condemnation of Israeli actions in Gaza. [Brasil de Fato+1](#)[Brasil de Fato+1](#)
- **November 16, 2024 – Rio de Janeiro:** A pro-Palestinian march was held in Copacabana ahead of the G20 summit. Protesters carried Palestinian flags and banners demanding that Israel's allies cease financing its military operations in Gaza and Lebanon. [France 24+1](#)[Jordan Times+1](#)
- **October 2023 – São Paulo and Brasília:** Protests were organized calling for a ceasefire in Gaza, with participants highlighting the humanitarian crisis and urging for an end to hostilities. [Jordan Times+5](#)[Agência Brasil+5](#)[Wikipedia+5](#)

Institutional and Legislative Actions

- **July 1, 2025:** The Brazilian Federal Senate passed a law establishing an official "Day of Friendship with Israel," signaling institutional support for Israel amidst the broader public's pro-Palestinian sentiments.
- **July 8, 2024:** Brazil ratified a free trade agreement with the Palestinian Authority, aiming to contribute to an economically viable Palestinian state. This move was seen as a demonstration of support for the Palestinian people. [Reuters](#)

International Solidarity and Activism

- **June 2025 – Gaza Freedom Flotilla:** Brazilian activist Thiago Ávila participated in the "Madleen" vessel, which attempted to deliver humanitarian aid to Gaza. After being intercepted by Israeli forces, Ávila was detained and later deported to Brazil. His involvement highlighted Brazil's active participation in international pro-Palestinian movements. [Wikipedia](#)

- **July 2024:** Brazilian-Palestinian organizations proposed that BRICS+ countries lead peace efforts and reconstruction in Gaza, aiming to provide an alternative to plans proposed by Israel and the U.S. [Brasil de Fato](#)

Academic and Cultural Engagement

- **May 7, 2024 – University of São Paulo:** Students occupied a building to protest against Israeli actions in Gaza, reflecting the active involvement of academic institutions in the pro-Palestinian movement. [Wikipedia](#)

These developments indicate a robust and multifaceted pro-Palestinian movement in Brazil during this period, encompassing mass mobilizations, legislative actions, international solidarity, and academic engagement.

PROMPTER

Have pro-Palestinian actions and expressions faced any opposition in Brazil?

CHATGPT

Yes, pro-Palestinian activism in Brazil between mid-2024 and July 2025 has encountered notable opposition from various sectors, including government institutions, political figures, and segments of the media.

BR Government and Institutional Responses

- **Military Contracts:** Despite public outcry, the Brazilian government continued to uphold military agreements with Israel. Notably, in May 2024, the Brazilian Army proceeded with plans to purchase 36 howitzers from Israel's Elbit Systems, a deal valued at approximately BRL 1 billion (US\$193.6 million). This decision faced criticism from activists who viewed it as contradictory to Brazil's condemnation of Israeli actions in Gaza. [Brasil de Fato+1](#)[Brasil de Fato+1](#)
- **Diplomatic Tensions:** In April 2024, President Lula removed Ambassador Frederico Meyer from Tel Aviv following a diplomatic incident where the Israeli Foreign Ministry declared Lula "persona non grata." This move was in response to Lula's criticism of Israeli military operations, which he compared to actions by Hitler. The incident highlighted the complexities in Brazil's diplomatic relations with Israel. [Brasil de Fato](#)

Political and Media Opposition

- **Political Figures:** Some Brazilian politicians and public figures have expressed support for Israel, emphasizing the importance of maintaining diplomatic and trade relations. These individuals argue that Brazil should engage with all nations to promote peace and stability in the region. [Brasil de Fato](#)
- **Media Coverage:** Certain media outlets have been criticized for presenting a biased perspective on the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, potentially influencing public opinion against pro-Palestinian activism. [Agência Brasil](#)

Legal and Social Challenges

- **Legal Actions:** Pro-Palestinian groups have faced legal challenges in their efforts to hold Israeli officials accountable. For instance, in January 2025, a Brazilian

court sought to investigate an Israeli soldier accused of war crimes in Gaza. The Israeli government facilitated the soldier's departure from Brazil, raising questions about the effectiveness of international legal mechanisms in addressing alleged war crimes. [Financial Times](#)

- **Public Perception:** While there is significant support for Palestinian rights within Brazil, pro-Palestinian activists have sometimes been met with skepticism or opposition from segments of the population who view their actions as politically motivated or misinformed.

In summary, pro-Palestinian activism in Brazil has encountered multifaceted opposition, including governmental decisions to maintain military ties with Israel, political and media narratives that favor Israeli perspectives, and legal and social challenges to their initiatives.

PROMPTER

Have any pro-Palestinian activists, academics, cultural figures faced active persecution?

CHATGPT

Yes, between mid-2024 and July 2025, pro-Palestinian activists, academics, and cultural figures in Brazil have faced various forms of persecution, including legal actions, institutional pressure, and media attacks.

Academic and Institutional Persecution

- **Professor Reginaldo Nasser:** At the Pontifical Catholic University of São Paulo (PUC-SP), Nasser faced an investigation by the São Paulo Foundation (Fundasp) after an anonymous complaint. The inquiry focused on his political beliefs, including his support for the slogan “Free Palestine, from the river to the sea.” Nasser described the investigation as politically motivated and indicative of a broader effort to silence pro-Palestinian voices in academia. [Department of Public Diplomacy & Policy+1The New Arab+1](#)
- **Professor Bruno Huberman:** Also at PUC-SP, Huberman, who is Jewish, was subjected to accusations of anti-Semitism due to his pro-Palestinian stance. Both professors faced scrutiny from university authorities, raising concerns about academic freedom and the suppression of dissenting views. [The New Arab](#)
- **Luciana Genro:** A state deputy from the PSOL party and descendant of an Auschwitz survivor, Genro was sued for "anti-Semitism" after denouncing Israeli actions in Gaza. She was dismissed from TV Pampa and summoned before the Ethics Committee of the Rio Grande do Sul Legislative Assembly following pressure from local Zionist groups and far-right parliamentarians. [Department of Public Diplomacy & Policy](#)

Cultural Figures and Media Attacks

- **Carlos Latuff:** A Brazilian political cartoonist known for his depictions of the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, Latuff has faced accusations of anti-Semitism due to his work. He denies these accusations, considering them to be a dishonest defense of Israeli policies. [Wikipedia](#)

- **Thiago Ávila:** A Brazilian activist who participated in the "Madleen" vessel attempting to deliver humanitarian aid to Gaza, Ávila was detained by Israeli forces and later deported to Brazil. His involvement highlighted Brazil's active participation in international pro-Palestinian movements. [Wikipedia](#)
- **A Nova Democracia (AND):** An independent Brazilian newspaper, AND has faced censorship and legal threats for its pro-Palestinian reporting. In January 2025, the newspaper's YouTube channel was removed, prompting condemnation from journalists and activists who viewed the action as an attempt to suppress critical coverage of Israeli policies. [The Red Herald –](#)

Legal and Political Repercussions

- **Muslim M. A. Abuumar:** A Palestinian member of Hamas, Abuumar and his family were detained upon entering Brazil at the request of the U.S. Department of State. A federal judge initially halted the deportation but later approved it upon receiving police information. Abuumar's lawyer argued that the detention lacked a warrant and was politically motivated, emphasizing Abuumar's appearance on the U.S. government's terrorist watchlist. [Reuters+1samidoun.net+1](#)
- **Israeli Soldier Investigation:** In December 2024, a Brazilian federal court authorized a criminal investigation into an Israeli soldier for alleged war crimes in Gaza. The soldier reportedly fled Brazil after the investigation was initiated. Israeli officials criticized the move, accusing Brazil of surrendering to "pro-Palestinian legal terrorism." [The Jewish Chronicle](#)

These instances illustrate a broader pattern of challenges faced by pro-Palestinian voices in Brazil, encompassing legal actions, institutional pressures, and media censorship.

PROMPTER

The story envisages Lula as thinking of the genocide in Gaza that 'This was personal'. 'Personal' in what sense?

CHATGPT

When imagining Lula da Silva reflecting that the genocide in Gaza "was personal," several layers of meaning could be at play:

1. **Historical and Cultural Empathy:** Lula's personal background and Brazil's diverse society, which includes many people of Middle Eastern descent—Palestinians, Lebanese, Syrians—might make the conflict resonate more deeply with him. He may feel a personal connection to the suffering of civilian populations, especially since Brazil has a history of social justice activism and solidarity with oppressed peoples.
2. **Moral Conviction and Political Identity:** Lula's long-standing image as a leader who champions human rights and social justice could make the atrocities in Gaza feel like a direct challenge to his core values. The scale and nature of suffering—what he and others describe as a "genocide"—could strike him as a profound personal affront to his commitment to dignity and justice.

3. **Political Responsibility and Legacy:** As a president, Lula might see the situation as personal because of the political decisions and stances Brazil takes—or fails to take—that might influence outcomes on the ground. The tension between maintaining diplomatic/trade relations with Israel and condemning the violence could weigh heavily on him, making it a personal burden or a crisis that he feels morally compelled to address more forcefully.
4. **Human Connection:** Lula might have met refugees, families, or activists affected by the conflict, or heard firsthand accounts of loss and devastation. These encounters can transform abstract political issues into deeply personal human tragedies.

In sum, "This was personal" likely reflects a fusion of empathy, moral responsibility, and political consequence—a recognition that the suffering in Gaza is not just a distant geopolitical issue but a human tragedy that strikes at the heart of his values and conscience.